

Jackson County Sheriff says community cooperating in Nolan Wells investigation; new details emerge

July 8, 2026 by Megan Fayard (<https://www.wxxv25.com/bios/megan-fayard/>)

PASCAGOULA, Miss. (WXXV) — As the community continues to grieve, questions remain surrounding the tragic death of 18-year-old Nolan Wells.

New developments are continuing to emerge in this case, which has quickly drawn national attention. Just days after a body found on Horn Island was identified as missing teen Nolan Wells, we sat down with Jackson County Sheriff John Ledbetter to get the latest on where the investigation stands and what comes next.

"Still waiting on the truth to come out. Still waiting on as much accurate information as we can get," said Sheriff Ledbetter.



After Wells' body was recovered from the waters of Horn Island, the sheriff's department released that they are searching for further information regarding an altercation that took place on the island on the 4th of July. WXXV has first-hand information from an eyewitness stating that Nolan was not directly involved in an altercation on the island, but those with information surrounding the situation are encouraged to speak with law enforcement.

"We've already taken steps, as you've said, even before the positive identity was made. What we did yesterday, put out a call to action to the public for anyone with authentic information — videos, photos, first-hand witness information and knowledge of Horn Island that day involving Nolan, or someone that may have seen him, or knows him, or was around him. Just so we... for the truthfulness of our investigation, and to get as much as we can, because I think the family deserves the truth, and that's what we're here to provide for them and for the public," said Ledbetter.

Sheriff Ledbetter did confirm that all individuals involved in the investigation are cooperating with authorities.

"We've had a lot of cooperation thus far from the public coming forward and willing to speak to investigators, telling their account of what happened, or what they saw during that day. It has really helped us out quite a bit. Right now, I know time is of the essence, but folks want answers ten minutes ago, and unfortunately, that takes time to get the accurate information. It's going to take a little time for investigators to get that. It's gonna take a lot of hard work. That's what we're in the process of doing as we speak now," he said.

Though, at this time, the sheriff's office can not confirm a timeline of events leading up to Nolan's death, [the mother of one individual who was allegedly with Nolan on the 4th of July said in a social media post \(https://www.facebook.com/ashlee.cole.3110/posts/pfbid0b9T5JzH1y3PnaEyNCh56vi24ffMFwgj-W2QHdULM4nM9CD3xBStvcainQNmy2LPil\)](https://www.facebook.com/ashlee.cole.3110/posts/pfbid0b9T5JzH1y3PnaEyNCh56vi24ffMFwgj-W2QHdULM4nM9CD3xBStvcainQNmy2LPil) that Nolan was last seen at around 3 p.m. that day, and at 4:30 p.m., the boys he arrived on the island with left when their boat had issues and started taking on water. She says Nolan decided to stay on the island and return inland later with another group of friends. The mother noted that she and her husband were not present on the island at any point on Saturday.

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